

Class 9 English – Kaveri

Chapter 2: The Pot Maker

Detailed, Exam-Oriented Solutions & Question Bank

Chapter	The Pot Maker
Author	Temsula Ao
Textbook	Kaveri – Class 9 English
Type	Prose / Narrative
Key Characters	Sentila, Arenla, Mesoba, Onula, village elders

1. Chapter Information

Setting: The story is rooted in a community where traditional crafts are closely connected with livelihood, family identity and cultural heritage.

Central conflict in the narrative: Sentila’s strong desire to learn pot making comes into conflict with her mother Arenla’s practical concerns about the difficult labour and poor economic returns of the craft. The village elders, however, regard traditional skills as a community heritage that must be transmitted to willing learners.

Important names: Sentila – the determined learner; Arenla – her mother and an experienced pot maker; Mesoba – her father; Onula – the woman who helps Sentila master the craft; the village elders – guardians of community tradition.

2. Character Sketches

Sentila

Sentila is curious, determined and deeply passionate about pot making. She continues learning even when her family initially discourages her. She observes expert potters carefully, practises repeatedly and refuses to abandon her dream after repeated failures. Her perseverance finally enables her to master the delicate skill.

Arenla

Arenla is a skilled pot maker and a practical mother. Her opposition to Sentila’s choice is based largely on experience: pot making demands strenuous labour but provides little financial return. She prefers weaving because it appears more practical and profitable. Eventually, she recognises Sentila’s determination and becomes an important teacher.

Mesoba

Mesoba represents the community’s respect for traditional knowledge. He is concerned about his daughter’s future but also understands that inherited skills belong to the wider community and need to be passed on.

Onula

Onula is patient, supportive and generous. She recognises Sentila's sincere desire to learn and promises to teach her. Her guidance, encouragement and attention to Sentila's technique become crucial in the final stage of the learning process.

Village Elders

The elders act as custodians of cultural tradition. They remind the family that traditional skills cannot simply be withheld from someone who genuinely wishes to learn them. Their intervention protects the continuity of the craft.

3. Important Words & Meanings

Word	Meaning
vocation	a skilled occupation or profession
pittance	a very small amount of money
malleable	soft and capable of being shaped
tedious	boring, tiring and repetitive
exhaustion	extreme tiredness
spatula	a flat tool used for shaping or spreading material
kiln	a furnace used for firing pottery
firing	heating pottery in a kiln to make it hard and durable
fashioned	created or shaped
misshapen	having an incorrect or unattractive shape
perseverance	continued effort despite difficulty
momentous	very important or significant
vocational	related to a particular occupation or practical skill

4. Important Lines / Ideas

"Don't worry, little one, I shall teach you how to make a perfect pot."

Significance: This reflects Onula's kindness, encouragement and willingness to support Sentila's genuine interest.

Traditional skills belong to the community.

Significance: The elders' view stresses that cultural knowledge should be transmitted across generations rather than being treated as private property.

Sentila repeatedly tries despite failure.

Significance: Her repeated attempts establish perseverance as a major quality in the narrative.

The final successful pots resemble the expert potter's work.

Significance: This marks Sentila's achievement and shows that patient observation and practice can turn aspiration into skill.

5. Complete Textbook-Based Solutions

Reflect and Respond

Q. Look at the pictures given in the textbook and identify the vocations. List at least five more vocations.

Answer: The vocations shown include basket weaving, pot making/pottery, cloth weaving and carpentry. Five other vocations are blacksmithing, tailoring, masonry, pottery decoration and farming.

Q. What is common among the vocations shown?

Answer: They are skill-based occupations. Each requires practical knowledge, training, practice and experience.

Q. Why are such occupations important to a community?

Answer: They meet practical needs, provide livelihoods and preserve traditional knowledge. Many such occupations also express the cultural identity and craftsmanship of a community.

Check Your Understanding

Q. Do you think pot making is easy? If yes, why? If no, why not?

Answer: No. Pot making is difficult because the potter must obtain and prepare clay, soften it through repeated pounding, shape it with precise hand movements, dry the pots carefully and finally fire them in a kiln. The work is physically tiring, time-consuming and technically demanding. A small mistake in shaping or firing can spoil an entire batch.

Q. Would Sentila be able to fulfil her dream of becoming a pot maker? Give reasons.

Answer: Yes. Sentila's determination is stronger than the obstacles she faces. She observes skilled potters, practises repeatedly, seeks guidance and continues even after nearly a year of failure. Her persistence and careful observation ultimately help her master the technique.

Q. Do you think Onula's support helped Sentila? Give a reason.

Answer: Yes. Onula gives Sentila both technical guidance and emotional encouragement. She promises to teach her, observes her difficulty and directs her attention to the correct hand movements. This patient support helps Sentila overcome the barrier that repeated practice alone could not solve.

Q. Sentila observes her mother making pots. What does this tell us about her?

Answer: It shows that Sentila is observant, sincere and eager to learn. She understands that watching an experienced craftsman closely can reveal details that are difficult to learn through trial and error alone.

Q. Arrange the events of the story in the correct sequence.

Answer: The broad sequence is: Sentila develops a strong interest in pot making → she secretly observes skilled potters → her mother discourages her and prefers weaving → the community elders intervene because the craft must be passed on → Sentila continues trying but struggles to shape the clay → Onula offers guidance → Sentila observes the correct technique carefully → she successfully makes pots → her achievement confirms that a new pot maker has emerged.

Reading for Appreciation / Critical Reflection

Q. Why did Arenla prefer weaving for Sentila?

Answer: Arenla believed weaving was economically more practical. Pot making involved carrying clay from a distant riverbank, physically demanding preparation and long hours of work, yet brought only a small return. Weaving could be done indoors, in different seasons, and could provide a better income.

Q. Why did Sentila keep her interest in pot making secret?

Answer: She knew that her mother strongly opposed the idea because of the hardship and poor financial return associated with pottery. To avoid conflict and continue learning, Sentila chose to observe and practise quietly.

Q. Why did the village council summon Mesoba?

Answer: The elders were concerned that a traditional community skill was being withheld from a willing learner. They reminded the family that such knowledge belonged to the community and had to be transmitted to future generations.

Q. Why did Sentila fail to shape the clay successfully for so long?

Answer: The shaping process required delicate coordination, confidence and precise hand movements. Sentila became tense while attempting it, and the clay consequently failed to yield the desired form. Repeated failure also increased her frustration.

Q. What made Sentila's final success possible?

Answer: Her persistence was essential, but careful observation and proper guidance were equally important. Onula encouraged her, and Sentila eventually watched the exact hand movements needed to shape the clay. Once she understood the technique and relaxed while working, she succeeded.

Extract-Based Textbook-Style Questions

Extract: "Pounding the stubborn clay inside bamboo cylinders to soften it is also tedious."

Explanation/Answer: Arenla explains that pottery requires strenuous preparation and offers only a small financial return. This explains why she initially prefers weaving for Sentila.

Extract: "Don't worry, little one, I shall teach you how to make a perfect pot."

Explanation/Answer: The statement is made by Onula. It shows her supportive and generous nature and marks a turning point in Sentila's learning.

Extract: "As a result, the clay seemed unable or unwilling to yield the right shape."

Explanation/Answer: The sentence describes Sentila's repeated difficulty in shaping the clay. Her tension and lack of mastery prevent the clay from taking the desired form.

Extract: "Onula fashioned a beautiful pot."

Explanation/Answer: Here "fashioned" means "created" or "shaped". The sentence demonstrates the skill that Sentila is trying to acquire.

6. Very Short Answer Questions

Q. What vocation is at the heart of the chapter?

Answer: Pot making or pottery.

Q. Who is Sentila?

Answer: She is a young girl who dreams of becoming a pot maker.

Q. Who is Arenla?

Answer: Arenla is Sentila's mother and a skilled pot maker.

Q. Who supports Sentila's learning at an important stage?

Answer: Onula supports and guides her.

Q. Where was the clay found?

Answer: It was obtained from a riverbank about sixteen kilometres away.

Q. What was used to pound the clay?

Answer: Bamboo cylinders were used.

Q. What tool was used to shape the clay?

Answer: A spatula was used along with the potter's hand movements.

Q. What could ruin a whole batch of pots?

Answer: Over-firing or under-firing in the kiln.

Q. Why did Arenla favour weaving?

Answer: She considered it less difficult and more financially rewarding.

Q. What quality finally helps Sentila succeed?

Answer: Perseverance supported by careful observation and guidance.

7. Short Answer Questions

Q. How does the chapter show the difference between passion and practicality?

Answer: Sentila approaches pot making through passion: she is fascinated by the craft and persists despite failure. Arenla approaches it through practicality: she focuses on labour, income and family needs. The contrast shows that personal fulfilment and economic practicality can sometimes pull a person in different directions.

Q. Why is the village elders' intervention important?

Answer: The intervention establishes that traditional skills are not merely private techniques but part of community heritage. The elders protect the transmission of knowledge and remind the family that a willing learner should not be denied access to an important cultural skill.

Q. What role does observation play in Sentila's learning?

Answer: Observation allows Sentila to notice the subtle hand movements and rhythm that she had not been able to reproduce through repeated attempts. Once she studies the technique carefully, she can understand what she has been doing incorrectly and improve her performance.

Q. Why can Arenla's opposition not simply be called unsympathetic?

Answer: Arenla's resistance comes from experience. She knows how physically demanding pottery is and how little it pays. Her wish that Sentila learn weaving therefore reflects a mother's concern about

her daughter's future rather than a rejection of Sentila's abilities.

Q. How does the ending establish Sentila's achievement?

Answer: The successful pots demonstrate that Sentila has finally acquired the required technique. Her achievement validates her persistence and marks her entry into the tradition of pot making.

8. Long Answer / Analytical Questions

Q. Describe Sentila's journey from desire to mastery.

Answer: Sentila begins with a strong personal attraction towards pot making. Even though her mother does not encourage her, she secretly watches experienced potters and tries to understand the craft. The work is difficult: clay must be collected from a distant riverbank, pounded and shaped with precision, dried and fired carefully. Sentila struggles particularly with shaping the clay and experiences repeated failure. Instead of abandoning her goal, she continues learning. The community elders support the transmission of the skill, while Onula provides important encouragement and guidance. Sentila's careful observation of the correct technique finally enables her to succeed. Her journey shows that sustained effort, observation, guidance and patience can transform an aspiration into mastery.

Q. Explain the conflict between Arenla's wishes and Sentila's dream.

Answer: Arenla wants Sentila to learn weaving because she sees it as a more practical livelihood. Pot making is physically exhausting, requires clay to be carried from a distant place, takes considerable time and gives only a small financial return. Sentila, however, is attracted to the craft itself and wants to preserve and practise it. The conflict is therefore not simply between a parent and child; it is between economic practicality and personal passion. Eventually, the community's belief in preserving traditional skills and Sentila's persistence allow her dream to be realised.

Q. How does the story highlight the importance of preserving traditional skills?

Answer: The story presents pottery as more than a way of earning money. It is an inherited skill connected with the identity and history of the community. The village elders insist that such knowledge should be passed on to people who wish to learn it. Sentila's eventual success ensures that the craft continues into another generation. The story therefore suggests that traditional occupations can survive only when knowledge is shared and younger generations are encouraged to learn them.

Q. What qualities of Sentila make her an inspiring learner?

Answer: Sentila is curious, determined, patient and observant. She does not allow repeated failure to destroy her interest. She seeks opportunities to watch experts, practises even when the results are disappointing and accepts guidance when it becomes available. Most importantly, she continues working towards her goal without giving up. Her success demonstrates that perseverance is often essential when a skill cannot be mastered immediately.

9. Value-Based Questions

Q. What can students learn from Sentila's persistence?

Answer: Students can learn that failure during learning is not proof of inability. Difficult skills require practice, observation, correction and patience. A learner should use mistakes as feedback rather than as a reason to stop trying.

Q. Should traditional vocational skills be preserved? Give reasons.

Answer: Yes. Such skills can provide livelihoods, preserve cultural identity and carry practical knowledge across generations. Preservation does not mean rejecting modern education; it means

ensuring that valuable community knowledge is not lost.

Q. How should parents balance practicality with a child's interests?

Answer: Parents should consider financial realities while also listening seriously to a child's genuine interests and abilities. Open discussion, exposure to the realities of a profession and opportunities for skill development can help families arrive at informed decisions.

10. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why is the distance of the riverbank significant in the story?

Answer: It emphasises the physical effort involved in pottery. The clay is not easily available; it must be collected and carried from a distant place, adding to the labour of the craft.

Q. What does the kiln episode teach us about pottery?

Answer: It shows that pottery requires technical precision even after shaping. The firing stage must be controlled carefully because both over-firing and under-firing can destroy the finished work.

Q. Why is Onula's role significant even though she appears later?

Answer: She provides the encouragement and technical insight that help Sentila cross the final barrier in her learning. Her intervention demonstrates the importance of a good mentor.

Q. What is the significance of the final success for the community?

Answer: It means that an inherited craft has been successfully transmitted to another generation. Sentila becomes a new bearer of the community's traditional knowledge.

Q. How is the title 'The Pot Maker' appropriate?

Answer: The title refers directly to Sentila's goal and eventual achievement. It also points beyond one individual to the craft and tradition of pottery that the story seeks to preserve.

11. CBSE Competency-Based Questions

Q. A learner practises a skill repeatedly but continues to fail. Which approach from the chapter would be most useful? Explain.

Answer: The learner should combine practice with observation and feedback. Sentila's experience shows that repetition alone may not be sufficient; understanding the precise technique and receiving guidance can identify the reason for failure.

Q. A family discourages a traditional occupation because it gives low income. Based on the chapter, what two viewpoints should be considered before making a decision?

Answer: The economic viewpoint should be considered because livelihood and financial security matter. At the same time, cultural value, personal aptitude and the possibility of preserving the skill should also be considered.

Q. If Sentila had stopped after repeated failures, how would the ending change?

Answer: She would not have mastered pottery, and the community would have lost an opportunity to pass the craft to another generation. The story's message about perseverance and learning would also be weakened.

12. MCQs

Q.	Question	Answer
1	The central vocation in the chapter is: A. weaving B. carpentry C. pot making D. farming	C
2	Sentila's main desire is to: A. become a teacher B. become a pot maker C. leave the village D. become a trader	B
3	Arenla initially prefers that Sentila learn: A. weaving B. farming C. carpentry D. sculpture	A

Q.	Question	Answer
4	The clay is obtained from: A. a forest B. a market C. a riverbank D. a mountain	C
5	The riverbank is approximately: A. 6 km away B. 10 km away C. 16 km away D. 20 km away	C
6	The clay is pounded to make it: A. dry and brittle B. soft and malleable C. hot and hard D. coloured	B
7	The pots are finally fired in a: A. furnace B. kiln C. oven D. stove	B
8	Who promises to teach Sentila how to make a perfect pot? A. Arenla B. Mesoba C. Onula D. an elder	C
9	The word 'pittance' means: A. a large profit B. a very small amount C. a loan D. a reward	B
10	The village elders value pot making as: A. a temporary hobby B. a community tradition C. a modern business only D. an easy occupation	B
11	The word 'fashioned' in the context of making a pot means: A. destroyed B. created or shaped C. bought D. decorated with paint	B
12	Sentila's final success is mainly the result of: A. luck alone B. money C. perseverance, observation and guidance D. avoiding practice	C
13	Which quality best describes Onula? A. indifferent B. supportive C. impatient D. selfish	B
14	Why does Arenla oppose pottery for Sentila? A. She dislikes Sentila B. She considers pottery too easy C. She sees it as exhausting and poorly rewarded D. She wants Sentila to leave school	C
15	What does the elders' intervention mainly protect? A. a family secret B. a community skill C. a business contract D. a market monopoly	B
16	Which stage comes after shaping and drying the pots? A. painting only B. firing in the kiln C. selling immediately D. weaving	B
17	Sentila's failure at first is associated with: A. lack of interest B. tension and difficulty mastering the shaping technique C. lack of clay D. refusal to learn	B
18	The story ultimately presents learning as: A. instant B. dependent only on talent C. a process requiring effort and guidance D. unnecessary	C
19	A vocation is best defined as: A. a hobby without skill B. a skilled occupation C. a school subject D. a game	B
20	The ending signifies that: A. Sentila gives up B. pottery disappears C. a new pot maker has emerged D. weaving becomes compulsory	C

13. Answer-Writing Tips

1. Mention the relevant character or event directly in the opening sentence.
2. For 2-3 mark answers, write 3-5 clear sentences and support the answer with a detail from the chapter.

3. For long answers, organise ideas logically: point → explanation → textual detail → concluding statement.

4. Remember the key names: Sentila, Arenla, Mesoba and Onula.

5. Important factual details include the distant riverbank, preparation of clay, shaping with hand and spatula, drying, kiln firing, Arenla's preference for weaving, and the elders' emphasis on preserving community skills.